

him to cough up our money. Of course, unknown to Bauji, because I knew he would have severely disapproved.

I then worked as a trainee accountant in a chemicals firm at Fort for a few months, but the job was not to my liking. However, I could hardly afford to be choosy, given that financially our nose was just above water.

Call it coincidence or the hand of destiny at work, I bumped into Pradeep Mohan, my classmate in college, as I was lunching at my regular food stall one day. We had only been casual acquaintances in college, but we got chatting as though we had been thick friends back then.

Pradeep was working in the back office of a stockbroker, and his job was to maintain client records after the trades were done on the floor of the stock exchange. We caught up over lunch regularly after that first meeting, and a good rapport developed between us. He loved to talk, and I was a good listener. He would paint a vivid picture of the happenings in the stock market for me; about how fortunes were made and lost in a matter of hours, about the guile and the ruthless ways of big brokers, and the sway they held over powerful industrialists. But what caught my attention was his remark that one did not need a fancy degree or even formal education to succeed in the stock market. With a bit of skill, perseverance and, most importantly, luck, there was no limit to the money one could make from trading in shares. On my commute back home, I often reflected on my lunchtime conversations with Pradeep.